CHAPTER 31

JAMES vs JIMMY

As we prepare for the biggest challenge in English cricket, my work with Mark Bawden deepens. We don't speak much, but I begin to trust him increasingly and lean into what he thinks might be helpful. Mark begins to tell me that he thinks there are two sides to me. That one part is introverted, compassionate, cares a lot about people but keeps them at arm's length, hard to read and sensitive. That, he says, we could call James off the field. James overthinks and undercommunicates. Then there's Jimmy. Jimmy turns up when I cross the line. I tell him about how my dad wouldn't let me win at anything and we develop an understanding of how this has triggered and nurtured an ultra-competitive attitude. Jimmy needs to find a way to win. Jimmy is much more overtly emotional and driven. It rings true to me and is the first time I've thought about making this distinction. I begin to realise that sometimes I mix the two people up, where James might turn up on the field and be overly self-critical, become lost in an internal battle or be too soft or kind. Then, off the field, sometimes Jimmy will turn up when he's not needed and be difficult or moody.

Mark begins to talk to me about a theory called 'assassins and warriors'. He starts to say that when I find the balance between emotion and persistence, patience and skill, there is no one in the world who can bowl better than me. It's just, as he's observed from afar, when the emotion overrides, I lose my radar and self-sabotage my skill. The warrior mode, when in the right balance, is in the fight, ready to go to battle with the batter. The assassin mode is much more clinical, where you need to nail a plan with precision, detail and skill, like playing speed chess with the batter. Every super strength, when overdone, can become your weakness. You've